HOME CARE | OCTOBER 2026

Three Ways to Get Home Care in Alberta

Publicly funded home care comes through three doors. Most people are only shown one.

Regular home care *ALA arranges everything*	Client Directed (CDHCI) *You pick the agency*	Self-Managed (SMC) *You hire the person*
WHO CHOOSES THE WORKER ALA arranges the workers. You do not choose.	**WHO CHOOSES THE WORKER** You choose an agency from the Alberta Blue Cross list of registered providers.	**WHO CHOOSES THE WORKER** You find, hire and manage the person.
WHO IS THE EMPLOYER ALA or its contracted provider.	**WHO IS THE EMPLOYER** The agency.	**WHO IS THE EMPLOYER** You, or your legal representative.
PAYROLL AND TAXES Not your job.	**PAYROLL AND TAXES** Not your job. The agency bills Alberta Blue Cross.	**PAYROLL AND TAXES** Your job: payroll, CRA business number, deductions, Alberta employment standards, quarterly reports to ALA.
CONTROL Least	**CONTROL** Middle	**CONTROL** Most
WORK FOR YOU Least	**WORK FOR YOU** Middle	**WORK FOR YOU** Most
THE RATE Not something you manage.	**THE RATE** ALA sets a maximum hourly rate, stated in your Alberta Blue Cross letter. $35.03 an hour from October 1, 2026. Over that, you pay the difference.	**THE RATE** Comes from your assessment and agreement. Not published. Keep every letter.

How to start

Call the ALA Access Centre: 1-855-371-4122. Monday to Friday 8:00 am to 6:00 pm, weekends and holidays 8:00 am to 4:00 pm. Anyone can ask for an assessment. You do not need a doctor's referral.

After your assessment, **ask about all three options by name**, and which ones you qualify for.

Before you choose Self-Managed Care

You cannot pay family or friends. The brochure says: "Family members, friends and informal caregivers are not allowed to be hired as paid care providers."

You become an employer. Payroll, tax deductions and quarterly reports to ALA are part of the deal.

Keep your agreement and every letter. No SMC rate is published, so your papers are the only record of what you are owed.

Sources: Assisted Living Alberta Self-Managed Care and CDHCI brochures (September 2026); Assisted Living Alberta "Getting care" page; Alberta Blue Cross Provider Benefact BE012-0044 (September 2026). Read October 29, 2026. Full guide and fill-in letter: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app